



Jet

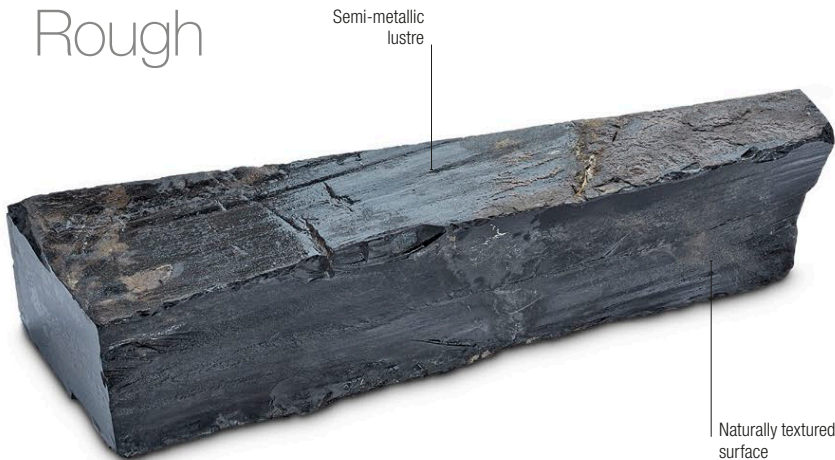
△ Sliced lump of jet showing wood grain

Jet is a type of lignite made from fossilized, compressed driftwood from the Araucariaceae family of trees – Chile pine, also known as monkey puzzle tree. Jet is composed of organic matter and, like coal, is readily flammable. Its colour – jet black – never fades, and its polished surface can be used as a mirror, as it was in medieval times. Like amber, when jet is rubbed it produces an electric charge, a property that made it popular as a talisman and earned it the name “black amber”. The best quality jet is found in Whitby, UK.

Specification

Chemical name Carbon | **Formula** C | **Colours** Dark brown, black, occasional brassy inclusions of pyrite | **Structure** Amorphous | **Hardness** 2.5–4 | **SG** 1.30–1.34 | **RI** 1.66 | **Lustre** Waxy | **Streak** Black to dark brown | **Locations** UK, Switzerland, France, USA, Canada, Germany

Rough



Jet block | This piece of high-quality jet shows the characteristic semi-metallic lustre found only in the finest and densest forms of the gem. The lustre is visible in this example both on its natural wood-textured surface and on its flat-sawn ends.

Original wood grain



Raw jet | This piece of beach-recovered jet – a common way of finding it – has a slightly brownish cast and shows some of the original wood-grain structure.

Cut



Oval cabochon | This oval jet cabochon has been polished with a number of flattened surfaces, giving it an appearance that almost looks faceted.

Fashion for mourning

Jet and mourning jewellery

Jet has been in use since the Bronze Age, but saw a huge resurgence during the Victorian era, largely due to Britain's Queen Victoria, who, grieving for her husband Albert, popularized the wearing of jet mourning jewellery. Whitby jet was also the only jewellery permitted at court, and the fashion soon spread to other parts of society, causing a surge in popularity.

Queen Victoria Britain's popular monarch played a part in the vogue for jet jewellery during her reign.



Healed natural crack



Whitby jet | Showing healed natural fractures, this piece of raw jet comes from Whitby on the northern coastline of the UK, which is famous as a source of jet.

Stress crack



Jet bead | This antique jet bead, which was originally hand-faceted and drilled, has cracked over time due to the release of internal stresses created by cutting it.